Minimalistic Men

By Spencer Davis

JERRY: *Mid-twenties. Maybe handsome, but at lights up, he's disheveled, having made a horrifying discovery.*
BRAD: *His roommate. Same age. Maybe frumpy. Clueless to the truth.*

SETTING: *Their apartment. Somewhere in America.* ***TIME:*** *Present day.*

Lights up on JERRY, standing DR, dialing his phone.

JERRY: **(Pg 161-168)** Come on, Brad, you son-of-a-gun, pick up. *(puts phone to ear, waits)* Pick up, pick up, pick up.

BRAD: *(D.S.)* Hey, this is Brad. If you're hearing this, I didn't pick up like you were anxiously hoping I would. So when the thing goes beep, say stuff. *Pause. Then "beep."*

JERRY: *(into phone)* Brad, it's Jerry. Look, I'm coming home. There's something really important I have to tell you, and we don't have much time. Just, um, don't. Do. Anything. I'm coming home. There's something really important I have -- *Damn*, I already said that. Look, I'm coming home. *Damn*. I said-*Damn*. *(hangs up) *Damn.* (looks at audience, furious)* Do you people *mind? JERRY exits R.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *According to Shakespeare: "All the world's a stage, and all the men and women merely players."*
ACTOR 2: *Just lines from another play, right? But what if they were true?*
TOGETHER: *Minimalistic Men by Spencer Davis*

Lights up on C, where BRAD sits on the couch, talking on the phone.

BRAD: *(into phone)* What do you mean I am? No way. ***You're*** the best. Okay, fine. But only if you do.

JERRY re-enters R, runs up to the side of the couch.

JERRY: Brad, we need to talk.

BRAD: *(oblivious to him)* No, you hang up first. No, you. No, you first. Gosh, you're ... what a rascal.

JERRY anxiously taps BRAD on the shoulder. (Brad still smiling) Oh, hey, Jerr. *(into phone)* No, you first. Okay, okay, fine. At the same time then.

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JERRY: Brad, we need to

BRAD: One, two, three. *(pause, then laughs hysterically)* Well, you didn't either.

JERRY: *(sternly)* Brad. Please. Come on. *BRAD looks at him, annoyed.*

BRAD: *(into phone)* Hey, I gotta go. Okay. I'll call you back, Mom. *(hangs up phone)* Have you no respect?

JERRY: Brad, I'm sorry. But this can't wait.

BRAD: Really? 'Cause I get to talk to my mom once a week. Once a week, for one hour. That's all the guards will allow her. And all I've asked is that you allot me that one hour to speak to her in peace.

JERRY: I know, Brad, but this can't wait an hour-

BRAD: *(looks down at caller I.D.)* Oh, and look. I have one missed call.

JERRY: Yeah. That was me calling.

BRAD: Oh. Well remind me to call you back later. *BRAD walks DL, to the stove. JERRY watches him; already he is almost drained.*

JERRY: Brad. What are you doing?

BRAD: I'm making ramen noodles. Is that alright, or are you going to interrupt me before I add the flavoring?

JERRY: *(desperately)* How can you think about food at a time like this?

BRAD: Most people think about food at lunchtime. *JERRY approaches BRAD, grabs his arm.*

JERRY: Listen, leave the noodles for a second. There's something very important I need-

BRAD: The noodles'll burn.

JERRY: If you don't listen to me, if you don't take me serious for two seconds, there aren't gonna be any noodles. *This, above all else, quiets BRAD.* This might sound strange, but I need you to listen: What we have here doesn't exist. *(pause)*

BRAD: Huh?

JERRY: All of this- *(motions to the apartment)* None of this is real.

BRAD: *("Nice try, bud")* Yeah, right. That lampshade over there alone is made of real wool. Trust me, I checked. It's posh.

JERRY: No, that's not what I - *(a new approach)* Right now, we're on display. *(pause)*

BRAD: You are high as hell.

JERRY: No.

BRAD: Yeah, yeah, you are. I can see it in your face.

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JERRY: Brad-

BRAD: Why do you do that to yourself? You smoke and then you run in spitting conspiracy theories. Like that time you swore, up and down, that Rachel Ray was the one who killed Bobby Kennedy.

JERRY: Read her book! It's all in there!

BRAD: And whenever I tried to convince you otherwise, you wouldn't stand for it. *(pause)* I can't prove it, but I'm pretty sure you overfed my goldfish in revenge for me debunking your theory

JERRY: Brad, ***we're*** *in a play! Silence.* We're in ... we're in a play. This is not our apartment, this is a stage. And look. Look. *(points BRAD towards audience)* Do you see them?

BRAD: See ... ? See who?

JERRY: Keep looking. One. Two. Three. "Stop acting." *JERRY snaps his fingers. House lights come up (and gradually fade down again) as BRAD sees the audience for the first time.*

BRAD: Wh-who are they?

JERRY: May I introduce ... the Audience.

BRAD: And, and they came here to what, watch us? Do what?

JERRY: I don't know. This. Talk. Disagree. Fight. Whatever.

BRAD: I, I need to sit down. *(sits down on couch; looks at it)* Holy *crap*! Where's our couch?

JERRY: That's what I've been trying to tell you. It wasn't ever a couch. Just two chairs pushed together. This whole thing uses a minimalistic set.

BRAD: *(nods knowingly)* A minimalistic set. Right. *(pause)*

JERRY: You have no idea what that means, do you?

BRAD: Nope. *(pause; a thought comes to him)* You know ... maybe a life on display isn't so bad, though. I mean, we can adapt. With people watching us, we'll be like celebrities. *BRAD preens in front of the newly discovered spectators.*

JERRY: Can you stop being so optimistic about this? You're forgetting the most important part of this whole thing. *(pause)* Every play ends. *The preening ceases. A moment of realization.*

BRAD: Oh *crap*.

JERRY: That's right. "Oh *crap*." That's what I really came here to tell you. Because see, when the play ends, so do we. When the lights black out- *(snaps his fingers)* We're dead.

BRAD: W-When is the play supposed to end?

JERRY: That's the part I don't know. A play can only last for so long. "August: Osage County" ran for three and a half hours. Even "The Norman Conquests" lasted about ten hours.

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BRAD: *(hopeful)* Great! So we might still have some time.

JERRY: Nah. I have a feeling we have ninety minutes, tops. You better just pray that we're not in a one-act.

BRAD: *(nods knowingly)* A one-act. Right.

JERRY: ... Never mind.

BRAD: But why does the play *have* to end? Why would it? I mean- *(points to audience)* They don't have to stay here. We could keep on

JERRY: Because that's what the Playwright wants. We have to do or say whatever He wants us to do or say.

BRAD: So some hipster types something into Microsoft Word and suddenly it's the Holy Grail.

JERRY: Well ... the Grail is a cup, but yeah, that's the idea. *BRAD rubs his forehead, thinking. Then, a curious realization.*

BRAD: How did you know?

JERRY: How did I know-what?

BRAD: All this. That we're in a play. That some guy is writing all this.

JERRY: *(realizes)* I ... don't know. I guess He sort-of imparted the knowledge to me. Before the play began.

BRAD: You think He wanted you to know that you're in a play.

JERRY: I guess so. Heck, everything we're saying right now might seem spontaneous, but it's all been ... preplanned. *(pause)*

BRAD: YOU'RE A . . . . YOU'RE A . . . *Booger eater*!

JERRY: *(taken aback, then)* WELL, YOU'RE A *SLIMEWAD*!

BRAD: No, not you. I was just trying to catch Him off-guard.

JERRY: Oh. Well, I don't think you *can* catch Him off-guard. Or Her. Or whatever the playwright is. There's not a line we've said so far that wasn't thought out ahead of time. For example, if I said, "This playwright blows," it's because He actually wanted me to say that.

BRAD: Wow ... So we're written by a misogynist.

JERRY: Masochist.

BRAD: Bless you. *(suddenly kisses JERRY; to the audience)* Sarah Palin. *[Could insert another current political figure here] (looks at JERRY, confused)* Oh! I'm so sorry! I didn't-

JERRY: *(unfazed)* It's okay. That was just the Playwright trying to be edgy ... and topical.

BRAD: *(sad understanding)* So ... there's nothing we can do to stop this, then.

JERRY: Nope. I suppose in a lot of ways, we're in the same position as the guy who discovered death.

BRAD: How'd he do that?

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ERRY: I guess he died. *The two men look at each other as it all sinks in. Pause for several beats. Then something in BRAD registers.*

BRAD: Then why did you tell me?

JERRY: ... What do you mean?

BRAD: I mean, you knew, before you even told me, that this play was going to end, no matter what we tried. So why couldn't you just let me die ignorant of my fate?

JERRY: You'd rather me keep that to myself? I did you a favor!

BRAD: Before you burst in here, and told me about the Audience, and the Playwright, and the Blackout, and the couch, I was fine. I was ignorant, but at least I was happy. If you making me conscious of my death doesn't prevent anything, then why couldn't you have just let me have my peace?

JERRY: *(comprehending)* Oh. Oh, Brad. Brad, I'm sorry . . . I didn't ... I never considered the implications of ... *BRAD scoffs, shakes his head in disgust.* Look, don't take this out on me. I can't help that I just did was I was written to do.

BRAD: No. Don't fall back on that "written this way" *crap*! Don't you try to-

JERRY: But I am! We have to do what we're written to do!

BRAD: Really? Well what if I'm written to *kick your ass! They scuffle. Its messy, clumsy, and very brief. By the end, BRAD has his hands around JERRY'S throat.*

JERRY: *(choking, breathless)* Stop, Brad! You're giving the Writer what He wants: Conflict!

BRAD: What's that, Jerry? I can't understand you. If I could stop strangling you, I might be able to, but I'm sorry. I'm just doing what I'm written to do! *JERRY knees BRAD in the groin. BRAD topples over. Both are lying on the ground, exhausted.*

JERRY: No! I won't let you give in. I won't let you have us reach a climactic confrontation! If we do, the scene will only end quicker. *BRAD pushes JERRY, one last weak effort, before sitting on the floor with his back against the chairs.* Brad-

BRAD: I can't do this, Jerry! I can't let some self-important douchebag decide how and when I'm going to die! I can't let it happen. I don't want to be minimalistic anymore, Jerry. Nothing will ever look the same again. *JERRY crawls over to his friend, sits down against the chairs too.* I just want it all to end. If it has to, I hope it's soon ... I don't want to have to think about it. *JERRY rests his hand on BRAD'S shoulder.*

JERRY: I know, I know.

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BRAD: I just want it all to end. *They look at each other. They accept it.* Right ... now. *They snap their fingers simultaneously. Lights out.*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Spencer Davis
Book: Best Ten-Minute Plays of 2012, Pgs 161-168
ISBN: 978-1575257938
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): June 2013

AWARD HISTORY

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